SAMPLE

Hope and Fear: The Two Wings of the Soul

A Reflection on Rajā' and Khawf

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Introduction

The soul in the Qur'an is called to walk a path. The path has two sides -- a right side and a left side, a rising and a falling, a reaching and a retreating. The soul that walks only one side does not walk straight. The soul that hopes without fearing becomes complacent. The soul that fears without hoping becomes paralyzed. The straight path is the path between -- the path of the one who hopes in Allah's mercy and fears His justice, the one who reaches toward the Garden and retreats from the Fire, the one who loves Allah and is mindful of Him at the same time.

This book is about the two wings of the soul: *rajā'* (hope) and *khawf* (fear). These are not emotions in the ordinary sense. They are orientations of the heart toward Allah -- the heart turned toward His mercy and the heart turned away from His displeasure. They are the two movements that keep the soul in motion, the two forces that keep the soul upright, the two wings that carry the soul to Allah.

The Qur'an speaks of hope and fear as paired. It says: "Their sides forsake their beds, they call upon their Lord in fear and in hope" (32:16). It says: "And they call upon Us in longing and in fear" (21:90). It says: "Call upon your Lord with humility and in secret. Indeed, He does not love the transgressors" (7:55). The fear and the hope are mentioned together, as if the Qur'an refuses to separate them, as if the soul must hold both at once.

The fear without the hope is despair. The despair is the state of the one who says: "Allah will not forgive me." The Qur'an says: "Do not despair of the mercy of Allah" (39:53). The despair is the whisper of Shaytan, who said: "No one will forgive me." The hope without the fear is complacency. The complacency is the state of the one who says: "Allah will not punish me." The Qur'an says: "Did they feel secure from the plan of Allah? But no one feels secure from the plan of Allah except the losers" (7:99). The complacency is the illusion of the one who trusts in Allah's mercy while ignoring His justice.

The balance is the way of the prophets. The prophets hoped in Allah more than anyone -- they trusted His promise, they relied on His mercy, they turned to Him in every need. And the prophets feared Allah more than anyone -- they were mindful of Him, they wept in His presence, they prayed until their feet swelled. The prophet who hoped without fear would be presumptuous. The prophet who feared without hope would be broken. The prophet held both -- the hope that carried him forward and the fear that kept him humble.

This book is the tenth and final book in the Lessons from the Qur'an series. It is the culmination of the journey that began with prayer, that continued through charity and fasting and pilgrimage, that deepened through patience and gratitude and forgiveness, that purified through sincerity and trust and remembrance, and that arrives here -- at the two wings that carry the soul to Allah. The hope and the fear are not the end of the path. They are the wings of the path. They are what makes the path walkable, what makes the journey possible, what keeps the soul in motion toward its Lord.

The book is for the one who hopes and the one who fears, the one who reaches and the one who retreats, the one who loves and the one who is mindful. It is for the one who walks between -- the one who holds the mercy and the justice, the promise and the warning, the Garden and the Fire, in one heart, at the same time, without letting go of either.

Come, let us walk.

Chapter 1: The Two Names -- Rajā' and Khawf and the Meaning of Hope and Fear

The word *rajā'* (رجاء) comes from the root R-J-', which means "to return," "to go back," "to look back toward." The hope in Arabic is not a wish projected forward into emptiness -- it is a turning back toward something that is already there. The one who hopes is the one who returns to Allah, the one who looks toward Allah, the one who faces Allah with expectation. The hope is not the hope in nothing. The hope is the hope in Someone -- in the One who is merciful, the One who is generous, the One who has promised and does not break His promise.

The Qur'an uses the word *rajā'* and its derivatives to describe the orientation of the believer toward Allah. It says: "And those who believe in what has been revealed to you and what was revealed before you, and of the Hereafter they are certain" (2:4). The certainty of the Hereafter is the hope -- the hope that the meeting with Allah is real, the hope that the promise is true, the hope that the reward is waiting. The hope is not a vague feeling. It is a conviction. It is the conviction that Allah is who He says He is, and that He will do what He has said He will do.

The word *khawf* (خوف) comes from the root KH-W-F, which means "to fear," "to be afraid," "to be cautious." The fear in the Qur'an is not the fear of terror -- the fear that paralyzes, the fear that destroys, the fear that makes the soul shrink. The fear of Allah is the fear of mindfulness -- the fear that awakens, the fear that protects, the fear that makes the soul stand upright before its Lord. It is the fear of the one who knows that Allah sees, that Allah hears, that Allah is near, and who lives accordingly.

The Qur'an uses the word *khawf* to describe the orientation of the believer away from what displeases Allah. It says: "And fear Allah and know that you will meet Him" (2:223). The fear is connected to the meeting -- the one who fears is the one who knows that the meeting is real, that the encounter is coming, that the standing before Allah is certain. The fear is not the fear of punishment alone. The fear is the fear of the One -- the fear of standing before the One who is just, the One who is knowing, the One who sees what the soul has done.

The Qur'an does not separate the hope and the fear. It mentions them together. It says: "Their sides forsake their beds, they call upon their Lord in fear and in hope" (32:16). It says: "And they call upon Us in longing and in fear" (21:90). It says: "Is one who is devoutly obedient during periods of the night, prostrating and standing, fearing the Hereafter and hoping for the mercy of his Lord" (39:9). The pairing is the pattern -- the hope and the fear together, the reaching and the retreating together, the love and the mindfulness together.

The pairing is not accidental. The soul needs both. The hope without the fear is presumption -- the one who says: "Allah will forgive me regardless." The fear without the hope is despair -- the one who says: "Allah will not forgive me at all." The balance is the one who says: "I hope in Allah's mercy and I fear His justice." The balance is the one who holds both -- the reaching toward the Garden and the retreating from the Fire, the trust in the promise and the mindfulness of the warning, the love of Allah and the awe of Allah -- in one heart, at the same time.

The scholars describe hope and fear as the two wings of the bird. The bird cannot fly with one wing. The bird with only the wing of hope flies into complacency -- it soars without direction, it glides without purpose, it lands anywhere. The bird with only the wing of fear falls into despair -- it cannot rise, it cannot move, it stays on the ground. The bird with both wings flies straight. It rises and it navigates. It reaches and it adjusts. It moves toward its destination with both the power of hope and the guidance of fear.

The two wings are the two movements of the soul toward Allah. The hope is the movement toward -- the reaching, the stretching, the yearning. The fear is the movement from -- the retreating, the correcting, the purifying. Together, they keep the soul in motion. Together, they keep the soul upright. Together, they carry the soul to Allah -- not in a straight line of presumption, not in a collapse of despair, but in the living, breathing, walking, flying path of the believer.

The hope and the fear are not abstractions. They are the daily life of the believer. The believer wakes in the morning and hopes in Allah's mercy -- the mercy that gave another day, the mercy that gave another chance, the mercy that gave another breath. And the believer wakes in the morning and fears Allah's justice -- the justice that sees what the soul does, the justice that records what the soul says, the justice that will ask what the soul has done with the day. The hope and the fear are the first thought of the morning and the last thought of the night. They are the rhythm of the believer's life.

The believer who hopes is not passive. The hope is not the hope of the one who waits for Allah to do everything. The hope is the hope of the one who acts -- who prays, who gives, who strives, who turns, who tries -- and who trusts that Allah will accept. The believer who fears is not paralyzed. The fear is not the fear of the one who cannot move. The fear is the fear of the one who moves carefully -- who watches the step, who guards the tongue, who checks the heart, who lives as one who will be asked.

The hope and the fear are the two names of the soul's relationship with Allah. The hope says: "Allah is merciful." The fear says: "Allah is just." The hope says: "Allah will forgive." The fear says: "Allah sees." The hope says: "The Garden is real." The fear says: "The Fire is real." The soul that holds both is the soul that walks straight. The soul that holds both is the soul that flies. The soul that holds both is the soul that arrives.